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Iranian Cultural Interference in Ancient Western Georgia in the Light of Archaeological and Linguistic Data*

Historical-cultural interrelations of pre-Islamic Iran and Ancient Georgia reveal the most ancient tradition.

Rich archaeological materials, pieces of historical evidence and epigraphic monuments discovered during archaeological excavations in the Black Sea region, on the territory of Ancient Colchis (Vani, Atskuri, Sairkhe, etc.) attest Iranian-Georgian miscellaneous cultural interferences during Achaemenid and post-Achaemenid times.

Ancient Iranian influences were extensively reflected in Kartvelian languages (Georgian, Mingrelian and Svan). In this respect, Iranian proper names of Scythian and Sarmatian origin are of particular interest. Already IV-III cc BC Greek inscriptions from Vani exhibit Ancient Iranian names of Colchian officials - Ὀραζο and Χορσιπ. Svanian and Mingrelian reveal a number of Scythian as well as Sarmatian proper names with correspondences to be traced in Northern Black Sea Greek inscriptions.

Key words: Colchis, Achaemenian and post-Achaemenian cultural-linguistic influences

Historical-cultural relations of Georgia with the Ancient Orient has a centuries-old history.

From the 5th millennium BC, the role of the Caucasus was clearly distinguished in global relations. During the Bronze age (c. 3300–1200 BC) its significance has become more evident and by the end of the 2nd millennium BC, relations of the outer world with the Caucasus region, particularly its western part - the Colchis kingdom (established at the end of the 6th century)¹ were extremely important.

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¹ About Ancient kingdom of Colchis and all bibliography see: Encyclopaedia Iranica, articles by F. Thordarson and Bruno Jacobs. Fridrik Thordarson, “COLCHIS,” *Encyclopaedia Iranica*, VI/1, 1992, pp. 41-42, available online at

These relations, which were conditioned by high economic and state growth of the Colchis kingdom, intensively developed with Western (Aegean civilization) as well as with South and Eastern worlds (ancient Mesopotamia, Iran).

In the present paper we will discuss some essential issues of Ancient Iranian impact on Colchis according to archaeological evidence and linguistic data.

Apparent contacts with the Ancient Iran are primarily revealed in Colchian group burials. These artifacts are presented by the third type whole cast daggers discovered in the burial # 1 of Ergeta, burial pit #5 (2 items), burial pit #7 (1 item), the burial #3, burial pit #2 (1 item) and in the burial of Dghvaba, burial pit # 1 (2 items).

These daggers are known as «Minor Asian» type daggers having close analogy with the Hasanlu IV daggers' type (Pogrebova 43; Mikeladze 57); From the same graves comes also the Sevan dagger (cf. Papuashvili 13-15). The Hasanlu IV type daggers (Haerink, Overlat 31-70) are also known from graves of Tlia (burials ## 236, 51, 97). Discovery of this type daggers (table 1-1) confirms that they continue to exist till 600 BC (Mikeladze 57).

Iranian artistic influences are also clearly distinguished in the South Georgia, namely in the cenotaph of Mzetamze burial, where a bronze dagger was found (table 1-2). The closest analogies of this dagger are traced among the objects grouped by Peter Calmeyer, (N31-35) and unified with artifacts belonging to the Neo-Babylonian period (Moorey 113-129; A diagram of Calmeyer's Groups 31-53).² It could be asserted that this dagger was made in Luristan (western Iran). In the Mzetamze burial, where penetration of the Colchian culture is obvious for that period, shin- ringlets are also found (table 1-3), having not only analogy with the Tlia burial, but direct and synchronic parallels with Luristan findings, namely, Gul Khanan grave complex (burial #37) in which the dead is buried in the embryonic posture with shin-ringlets (Kakhidze 35).

<http://www.iranicaonline.org/articles/colchis>; Bruno Jacobs, *Caucasus III, Achaemenid Rule in the Caucasus*, 2006, online version: <http://www.iranicaonline.org/articles/caucasus-iii>.

² In my first publication concerning the dagger exactly this date - VII-VI cc BC was given (Licheli 1999, 363).

The fact of wide spreading so-called jugs with a tubular handle (table 1-4) in the whole Colchis may emphasize the earliest Iranian-Colchian cultural contacts (Otar Lortkipanidze, Gogolashvili, Kacharava, Licheli 34-36; Otari Lortkipanidze 1971,21). These jars are mostly found in all VII-IV cc BC archaeological monuments of Western Georgia: Batumi Castle, Pichvnari, Kokhi, Simagre, Ochamchire, Ergeta, Mtisdziri, Dablagomi, Kutaisi, Qulevi, Brili, etc. During last years a number of such jugs were excavated on the territory of Eastern Georgia. This type of ceramics is first revealed in Western Iran (recently, in Qalaichi, cf. Fine Ware, 800-600 BC (Moorey, 1967,33-35).

Achaemenians have already appeared in Colchis during the reign of Darius I (590-486 BC). As Bruno Jacobs states: «Achaemenian domination in the Caucasus was established in 513-512 BC, during the Persian king's campaign against Scythians» (Jacobs 184). Persians' activities in Northern-Caucasian area were limited and archaeological findings show that the Caucasus was forming the northern frontier of the Empire throughout the Achaemenid era (550-330 BC), or at least after Darius I's reign (Jacobs 184).

Several researchers shared this opinion (Waldbaum 8-15), although there also existed a completely different point of view (Otar Lortkipanidze 1985 141-165). Archaeological background of the written sources of this period is as follows: there are two administrative centers revealed in the Colchis area, where, according to the luxury burials of V-IV cc BC, Colchian aristocracy is supposed to resided. These centers are Vani and Sairkhe. At the same time, this period for Colchis is the time of the especially intense relationship with the Greek world (Otar Lordkipanidze 1966). Uniformity of metal works, standardization of ceramic ware, activation of monetary circulation, and administrative division of the country enabled some researchers to think that Colchis of this period was a unified, politically and economically developed state (Melikishvili; Mikeladze; Otari Lortkipanidze 1972). It is well known that the influence of Achaemenid culture was strong in the Colchis area and is particularly well reflected in the Colchian art (fine samples of goldsmith from Vani and Sairkhe (Chkonias 8)). Though significant regional cultural differences are clearly distinguished between the Colchis

shoreline and the inner Colchis: the coastal settlements are of Greek orientation and Achaemenid cultural tendencies are much less discernable there.

The archaeological material dated by V-IV cc BC found on Greek and Colchis necropolises from Kobuleti - Pitchvnari clearly attests it (Thomatos fig. 2, 43-69). The overwhelming majority of these materials in this burial is Greek or local and in this respect, it is interesting to see the IV c BC Achaemenid type bridle discovered by chance in the village Chibati (tab1 -6).

To rare finds belongs a kohl-tube of Iranian production found in Kobuleti-Pichvnari burial (I group attributed by D. Barag, dated by the second half of the V c BC (Kakhidze 31-47; Licheli 2011, 139) and the Achaemenid type rounded golden bracelet. Thus, the Achaemenian trends in V-IV cc BC inventory from Vani and Sairkhe are mostly obvious.

It is sufficient to mention the theme of a lion and bullfighting on the Vani diadem; Achaemenid bracelets, or decorations of a silver belt found in the burial # 24, where the Achaemenid cup is presented (Kacharava, Kvirkvelia 293); Or golden pendants from Sairkhe (table 1-5) with the image of Ahura-Mazda (Papuashvili 13-15), a silver rhyton from Mtisdziri (Gamkrelidze 1999, 211-216); As it was supposed «The élite of Colchis was familiar with Aramaic, the language of administration in the Persian empire» (Braund 126). At Sairkhe, for example, a kylix of the 5th c BC bears on its base a monogram in Greek and Aramaic letters (126);³ At the same time, Achaemenid type bridles, shroud-adornments (golden images of eagles) corresponding to Achaemenid royal standards, a capital with double protoma (Tsurtsunia 160-196) and some other items were found at Sairkhe.

On the road joining Vani-Atskuri⁴, which was one of the main ways for transferring Greek import accumulated in Colchis (Licheli 1999, 33-34) Achaemenian coins (Otar Lortkipanidze 2002, 207) were discovered.

³ Aramaic letters can also be read on the parts of gold-leaf from Vani, see Braund, 126, n. 22.

⁴ Here the most important items of post-Achaemenid period were found, cf. a stylized image of Ahura-Mazda, see below, the table 1-7.

These coins were found on the territory of the village Sulori located at the beginning of the transitional way from Colchis to South Georgia. The treasure contained nearly 700 silver coins and their major part consisted from Colchian silver coinage («Colchian tetri»). Together with them was discovered so-named krezoid (croesoid) minted in 500 BC by Darius I. There was also revealed the Achaemenid siclo (a type of coin) with an image of a crowned king armed with a lance, presumably having also been struck by Darius I in 490 BC (Otar Lortkipanidze 2002, 207).

Conceivably, interrelations with the Achaemenid Empire were limited to the internal regions of Colchis and the East Colchis became indeed a part of the Empire's satrapy (Jacobs 184)⁵, or this formal subjection only concerned the eastern part of Colchis. Consequently, it is easy to explain why the Greeks did not meet the Achaemenidians' confrontation in the Black Sea – there were no struggles in V-IV cc BC, especially in 436/5 BC, during Pericles' (494-429 BC) activities (for detailed analysis, see Braund 122 and following). However, it could be assumed that the Athenians have been activated already in seventies of 476/5 BC, when their city Byzantion was conquered, they inevitably dominated over the Black Sea channel and gained control of the trade routes (Otar Lortkipanidze 2002, 203).

It might be possible that local and Achaemenid cultural traditions were still co-existent in IV-III cc BC Vani architecture (Licheli 2011, 135-156). For example, we can name a fragment of limestone frieze, discovered in Vani with a depiction of a charioteer and a part of the chariot.

The studded wheel of the chariot is identical with the wheels of the chariots found in Achaemenid representations: such as, on Darius I's signet-ring, on the gold chariot of the Amu-Darya treasure, preserved at the British Museum (Boardman 191-238) as well as on the reliefs of Apadana (Littauer, Crouwel 144-149). Similar wheels are also discovered at Uplistsikhe (Eastern Georgia). The architectural detail from Vani, which must have been that of the frieze of a monumental building (it was painted, a trace of the paint survives), attests that the

⁵ However, there are several objections, see Otari Lortkipanidze 2002, 207; Pogrebova, 10.

Achaemenid tradition was still discernible in this «city»⁶. Besides, the preservation of Achaemenid tradition is proved by the imitation of a double-protoma clay capital and a clay rhyton, painted in Achaemenid style.

From the III c BC the situation extremely changes and on the entire territory of Colchis, against the framework of local culture, the Greek element – really, rather weakly, yet geographically, begins to spread widely.

Later in this area occur new, different elements associated with Sarmatic culture. Relations with Sarmatians are clearly reflected in classical records⁷(as it was known, in the 35AD Parthians attempted to conquer its province Armenia. The emperor Tiberius (14-37AD) asked his “ally”, the king of Iberia, Parsman I (died 58) to support him in this struggle. Parsman I together with Sarmatian and Albanian warriors attacked Parthians at the river Araxes (Gamkrelidze 2014, 129)).

Sarmatian-Kartvelian relations are equally revealed in archaeological material. Sword handles and daggers discovered in Georgia attest that they were mainly spread in IV-I cc BC and the area of their distribution remains mostly the Western Georgia, for the present (Gamkrelidze, Pirtskhalava, Shatberashvili 80).

Formal signs – flat handle, one of the variations of the sword (I, Id) are swords with a ring-handle, known in scientific literature as “ring-handle or Sarmatian swords”. They are distinguished by a specific head-handles having 4-4,5 cm diameter ring and are of refined style. On their surface are often wooden sheath impressions. There are distinguished bimetallic handle samples: they have a bronze handle and contained bimetallic shaft, on the stem of the iron shaft wooden cladding was made by three tacks. One sample of this wooden cladding is covered with a bronze thin ring; The wooden material placed on the tire of another cladding was attached to the handle by the bronze bar. The weapon is crowned by a bronze ring handle (Gamkrelidze, Pirtskhalava, Shatberashvili, Charkviani, Davlianidze 80). These types of

⁶ For a different interpretation, see Otar Lordkipanidze 2002,207

⁷ Tacitus, Annals, IV, 33-35; VI, 34, XIV, 23; See also Braund 219-220.

swords appear in Georgia in I and II cc AD. They are found in many geographic points of Georgia. The ring-handle swords are found in Dzevri (II c AD), Lia, Bori, Khabume, Inashauri and the village Zeda Gora. Zeda Gori and Inashuri swords according to parallel materials are dated by I-II cc AD.

Four ring-handle swords are known from Chkhari, another four swords - from Zhinvali (NN282, 383, 499 and 525 burials) (Gamkrelidze, Pirtskhalava, Shatberashvili, Charkviani Davlianidze 80). It should be noted that among ruins of the Dedoplis Gora palace was found a bone plate (I c BC) with a depiction of an armed rider, on his right he has a ring-head dagger, or a short sword, stressing popularity of this type of weapons.

Noteworthy that ring-handle swords outside Georgia are fixed on a large territory, from Eastern Europe to China. Their earliest samples date back only to the II c BC. They were mostly discovered in the North Caucasus and Northern Black Sea region (Taman peninsula), from I c BC –I-II cc AD. Images of ring-handle swords are known from reliefs and frescos of II-V cc AD. In the Caucasus they were discovered in Mingechauri as well.

As for Vani, in its Eastern sector, 15 kilometers further of the settlement, in the village Zeda Gora, in a burial dated by I-II cc AD were discovered an iron ring-handle sword, spearheads and an axe.

Such a dagger is known among other monuments of Vani region, namely from the village Inashauri. In this burial complex dated by I-II cc AD, the following weapons were found: an iron sword, two spearheads and an axe. If we consider these and some other facts, it becomes clear that the tombs with Sarmatian weapons always belonged to the lower layer of that society. Consequently, Sarmatian proper names so widespread among Georgian élité was not an ethnic characteristic but could rather designate a certain type of Kartvelian-Iranian political-military interrelations.⁸

⁸ Sarmatian proper names are mostly frequent in Aramaic and Greek inscriptions of pre-Christian Eastern Georgia (I-III cc AD). The first investigator of the Aramaic inscriptions of Georgia, Academic George Tsereteli, stated that «Many Iranian proper names were widespread in Georgiain the pre-Christian period», (Tsereteli 91).

Apart from Archaeological data, there is also epigraphy discovered in Colchis attesting Ancient Iranian cultural impact on this region.

The most earliest records indicating Iranian onomastics in Ancient Western Georgia are Greek inscriptions on local Colchian roof-tiles discovered in Vani in the early seventies.

Among local tiles is distinguished a group with royal stamps (nearly 50 units) having the following inscription: ΒΑΣΙΛΙΚΗ ΜΗΛΑΒΗ/Σ Βασιλική Μηλαβη/ς (N07:1-78/293).⁹ Βασιλική was interpreted as a separate attributive word for «royal» type of tiles – Κεραμὶς βασιλική (Akhvlediani 6). Μηλαβη/ς was a name of an official concerned with the production of tiles (6; Braund 135). Smaller stamps also occur on about half the tiles found, giving Iranian proper names ΟΡΑΖΟ 'Οράζο(υ) (N 07:1-78/292) and in some cases ΧΟΡΣΙΠ Χορσιπ (N 07: 1-76/147, N 07:1-88/678); These tiles from Vani have the following sizes: their length is 60±5 cm, width – 50±5 cm and thickness – 2,4 cm (Akhvlediani 15,30)).¹⁰ Apparently, these also were the names of royal officials, though not so high-ranked as Μηλαβη/ς (9). The most earliest tiles with these stamps occur in levels of the late IV and early III cc BC, though the bulk of them have been discovered in destruction-levels of the II-I cc BC (6, 10-11).¹¹

The Iranian name ΟΡΑΖΟ 'Οράζο(υ) is presumably originated from Ancient Iranian (Median) form *Varāza «boar» attested in Old Iranian and non-Iranian (Aramaic, Babylonian, Elamite) records (Tavernier 338-339 Nr.4.2 1802; Schmitt 2016, 226, Nr. 546). It also occurs in Middle Iranian (Parthian, Middle Persian)¹² languages. In the III c Sasanian royal inscriptions¹³, in particular, in the trilingual (Middle Persian, Parthian and Greek) inscription of the king Shapur I (240-270) near Persepolis on Ka'ba-ye Zartosht (ŠKZ) a masculine proper name Warāz

⁹ A systematic study of the tiles from Vani was presented in Dimitri Akhvlediani's work – Akhvlediani, 1990, see also Braund 135, n. 56.

¹⁰ See table II with drawings - Akhvlediani 57; Paleography of the letters is presented in table III, Akhvlediani, 58; Facsimiles of these inscriptions are given in: Kaukhchishvili 150-151; 345. See also digital versions of these inscriptions: <https://epigraphy.packhum.org/regions/1088>.

¹¹ According to T. Kaukhchishvili's dating, some tiles with stamps bearing the name ΧΟΡΣΙΠ Χορσιπ could be attributed to later period, II c BC, Kaukhchishvili 151, cf. also Akhvlediani 10-11.

¹² For an example attested in Bactrian, see Sims-Williams 145, Nr. 505, 506; Schmitt 238-238 Nr. 577.

¹³ About this name in the inscription of the Sasanian King Narseh (reign 293-302) from Paikuli (293) see Gignoux 1971, 36, 66; Gignoux 1983 II/173, N 940; Schmitt 2016, 226, N 546; Cereti-Terribili 363.

is attested (Mid. Pers. ŠKZ 29, 31; Parth. 23, 25) with the corresponding Greek form Γουπαζ (Greek ŠKZ 62), Γοπαζου (Greek ŠKZ 57) (Back 268; Gignoux 1971, 36, 66; Gignoux 1986, 173, Nr. 940; Gignoux 2003, 65 Nr. 346; Huyse, 135a; Schmitt 2016, 226, Nr. 546). The inscription also shows feminine name and a title comprising Warāz, cf. Warāzduxt (Mid. Pers. ŠKZ 26; Parth. 23, 25; Greek Γοπαζδουκτ 50)¹⁴ (Gignoux 1971 36, 66; Buck 269; Gignoux 1986 II/174; Schmitt 2016, 226, Nr. 547) and a title Warāzbed, Greek Γοπαζιβιδ (ŠKZ 67/68) (Back 269).

Parallel forms of the name OPAZO Ὀπάζο(ν) could be traced in Scythian (or Sarmatian) proper names attested in Ancient Greek inscriptions of the Northern Black Sea¹⁵. In the inscription from Tanais occurs the name Οὐαράζακος = warāz with hypocoristic suffix -ak (Zgusta 125 § 168; Abaev 1949, 187; Abaev 1979, 307; Schmitt 2016, 227, Nr 548), cf. Parthian Warāzak (Gignoux 1972, 66; Livshitz 160, Nr 656; Schmitt 2016, 227, Nr 548).

Proper names with Warāz are shown in Ossetic –Wæraz, Uruzmeg (Abaev(a) 187, 284; Abaev(b) 307), also Wæræzmæg/Wyryzmäg, the name of the main character of the Nart sagas (187; 307; Fritz 226, 1582, Edelman 144)).

The name Warāz is broadly reflected in Kartvelian languages. Georgian Medieval Chronicles (XI c) often represent names of Georgian nobles, such as Varaz-Bak'ur, Varaz-Bakar, Varaz-Vard, Varaz-Mihr, Varazman (Andronikashvili 1966, 463-464; Chkheidze 1987, 101-102, Chkheidze 2001, 487; Rapp 263, 312; Cf. Armenian equivalent Varaz (Martirosyan 249, N 743)). Noteworthy that in Georgian records is attested a name Varaza, where the final -a is to be regarded as the reflection of Old Iranian suffix (Chkheidze 1984, 42). Svanian shows the name **Werzmeg** stemming from Nartian Wæræzmæg/Wyryzmäg (Abaev 1949, 301; Andronikashvili 1980, 41).

¹⁴ Ph. Gignoux gives the Middle Iranian transcription of this name as Gurāz as it occurs in Greek, probably following the real pronunciation of the name, Gignoux 1971 36, 66; cf. Schmitt, 2016, 226; cf. the New Persian gurāz “boar”, (Mackenzie 87), cf. also barāz (Edelman 143) On the Greek transcriptions of Middle Iranian Warāz, see Back 152.

¹⁵ On the digital corpus of the Northern Black Sea, see : <http://iospe.kcl.ac.uk/index.html>.

The name ΧΟΡΣΙΠ Χορσιπ also revealed on royal tiles from Vani (II-I cc BC) represents a two-stem compound, the first part of which is originated from Old Iranian (most probably Scythian) *hvar.¹⁶ Scythian *hvar, (Ossetic xor, xūr «the Sun, sunny») is widely reflected as Xop- in Scythian-Sarmatian proper names in the corpus of the North Black Sea Greek inscriptions: Χορόαθος (Tanais) (Zgusta 169-170 § 256; Abaev 1979, 291; Chkheidze 1984, 32; Edelman 176); Χορόξαθος (291).¹⁷

In Georgian onomastics are encountered some names comprising (Middle) Iranian *hvar, x^var, such as Xuaranže (Xuarandze)¹⁸ (Justi 91, 181-182), in XI c Georgian Chronicle «The Life of Vakhtang Gorgasali» by Juanšer Juanšeriani,¹⁹ the Iranian name of the King Vakhtang I Gorgasali's(440-502 AD)sister. A synonymic parallel of this name is Xuaramze (Andronikashvili 511-512; Chkheidze 1984, 33; Rapp 311); Cf. also feminine name Xvarešan, Xorešan < Middle Persian *x^varanšāhān (Andronikashvili 1966, 511, n.1). Iranian *x^var, x^varna(h) was preserved as well in Georgian geographic names, Xornabuji (Gamkrelidze, Mindorashvili, Bragvadze, Kvachadze 647-648; Rapp 306) and Xoranta (646-647).²⁰

The second component of the name Χορσιπ remains uncertain. Rather hypothetical interpretation of -σιπ belonged to Mzia Andronikashvili (orally) as the expression of Old Iranian spāda, spāda «army» (Middle Iranian spāh, New Persian sipāh) frequently occurring in Old Iranian personal names as a second part (Tavernier 564, 605); Cf. also Scythian

¹⁶ On the Old Iranian huṣar- and its reflections in Iranian languages, see Rastorgueva, Edelman 438-443.

¹⁷ V. Abaev interpreted Χορόαθος as «messenger of the Sun(rise)», while Χορόξαθος as «washed by the Sun», (Abaev 291).

¹⁸ It is significant that the inscription of Shapur I (ŠKZ) attests the feminine name Xōrānzēm (Mid. Pers. 25, 26; Parth. 20, 21) (Gignoux 1973, 24, 53, Back 222, Huyse 2, 116f, n. 196; Livshitz 97, Nr 268), Xorr • nzēm (Schmitt 110, Nr 226) Greek Χορνανζημ (Back 222, Schmitt 2016, 110, Nr 226) The name also occurs on a Sasanian seal (Gignoux 1986, II/185, Nr 1018). The first part of the name is originated from Ir. huṣarnah > * x^varna(h) «shining, royal glory, splendor, delight». The second part of the name M. Back derives from * (h)anjāmyā «a place of gathering» (Back, 222) Anyway, the etymology remains unclear, see Gignoux 1986, II/185, Nr 1018, Huyse 116-117; Schmitt 110, Nr 226. However, it should be mentioned that some Georgian scholars considered Georgian Xuaranže as related with this Middle Iranian name, see Chkheidze 1984, 33, cf. also Armenian P'aranjem < Parth. Xwarr • nzēm, (Martirosyan 278-79, N850).

¹⁹ According to recent publications, this composition is dated by late eighth or early ninth centuries, see Rapp(b) 271, n.3, also Rapp(a) chapters. 1, 3.

²⁰ Both are located in Eastern Georgia, in historical region named Kambechovani, where apparently in pre-Christian times existed Sun temple – pagan sanctuary (Lolashvili 208-2016).

(Sarmatian) Σπαδακος (II-III cc AD) (Olvia) (Zgusta 147, § 218; Abaev 1979, 303), Σπαδάκης (Justi 306) ; Σπαδάγας (Olvia), further form of the same name (Justi 306; 147 § 218, cf. Tokhtasyev 585) is attested as well by the Greek historian Arrian of Nicomedia (86-160 AD) in his work *Periplus Ponti Euxini* (11, 3(13) (306; 147, §218) as the proper name of the king of Sanig principality in Colchis (Abkhazia);²¹

In Georgian historical sources (IX-XI cc) frequently occurs *sp'a* «army» borrowed from the Middle Persian *spāh* (Andronikashvili 370-371), its corresponding Armenian forms are *spah* < Middle Persian *spāh* and *spay*, **spar* (*spar-a-pet* <«army-leader») < Parth. **spāδ* (Schmitt 1989, 101; Sundermann 106; Gippert 111-112, n. 15).

A supposed archetype for ΧΟΡΣΙΠ Χορσιπ could be reconstructed as **hvar/x'ar-spāda* from which stemmed the form *xors'p(ah* < *aδ*), (probably with a prothetic -i) «army (warriors) of the Sun/the Sun like army» (Andronikashvili).²² Its ancient semantic correlation (as indicated M. Andronikashvili) was found in the Georgian name and title *Mzeč'abuk'-i* «a young man/ knight of the Sun» (Justi 156) (Georgian *mze* «the Sun», *č'abuk'-i* «youth, knight» < Middle Persian (Pahlavi) *čābuk* «agile, nimble excellent» (Mackenzie 21); Cf. Armenian *čapuk* «quick, supple»; *Čapuk* occurs as a masculine name in Persian and Armenian (Justi 156; Martirosyan 167, N 408). *Mzeč'abuk'-i* represents the main character of the Georgian fairy tales associated with the Sun worshipping cult in Ancient Georgia (Cholokashvili 49-62). This name might have been also an Iranian (semantic) calque. It is significant that *Mzeč'abuk'-i* was a historical person known as the *atabag* (governor) of Akhaltsikhe (West Georgia) (in 1500-1515) (Justi 156).

Another epigraphic remain from Vani comprising ancient Iranian name and dated by IV-III cc BC is engraved on the inner wall of the small pagan sanctuary attached to the main entrance gate of the city.

²¹ On the coalescence of several ethno-political groups on the territory of Abkhazia in I-II cc AD see Dzhamshid Giunashvili, *ABKĀZ*, *Encyclopaedia Iranica*, vol. I, fasc. 2, pp. 222-224, 1982, online version: <http://www.iranicaonline.org/articles/abkaz>.

²²

the gate of Vani, a small Greek pagan inscription on the north wall of the small pagan shire built on the main wall, has a horizontal inscription engraved on the right from left to right on the first stone. has a horizontal inscription engraved on the right from left to right on the first stone.

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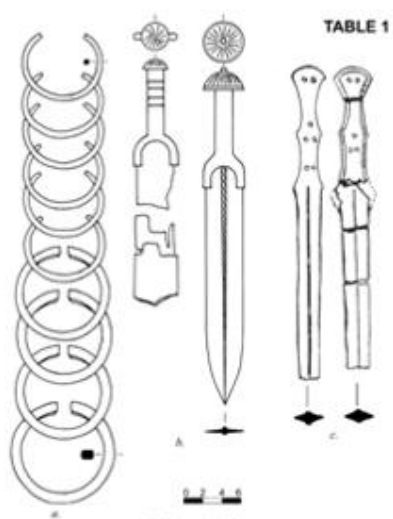
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Tables:



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